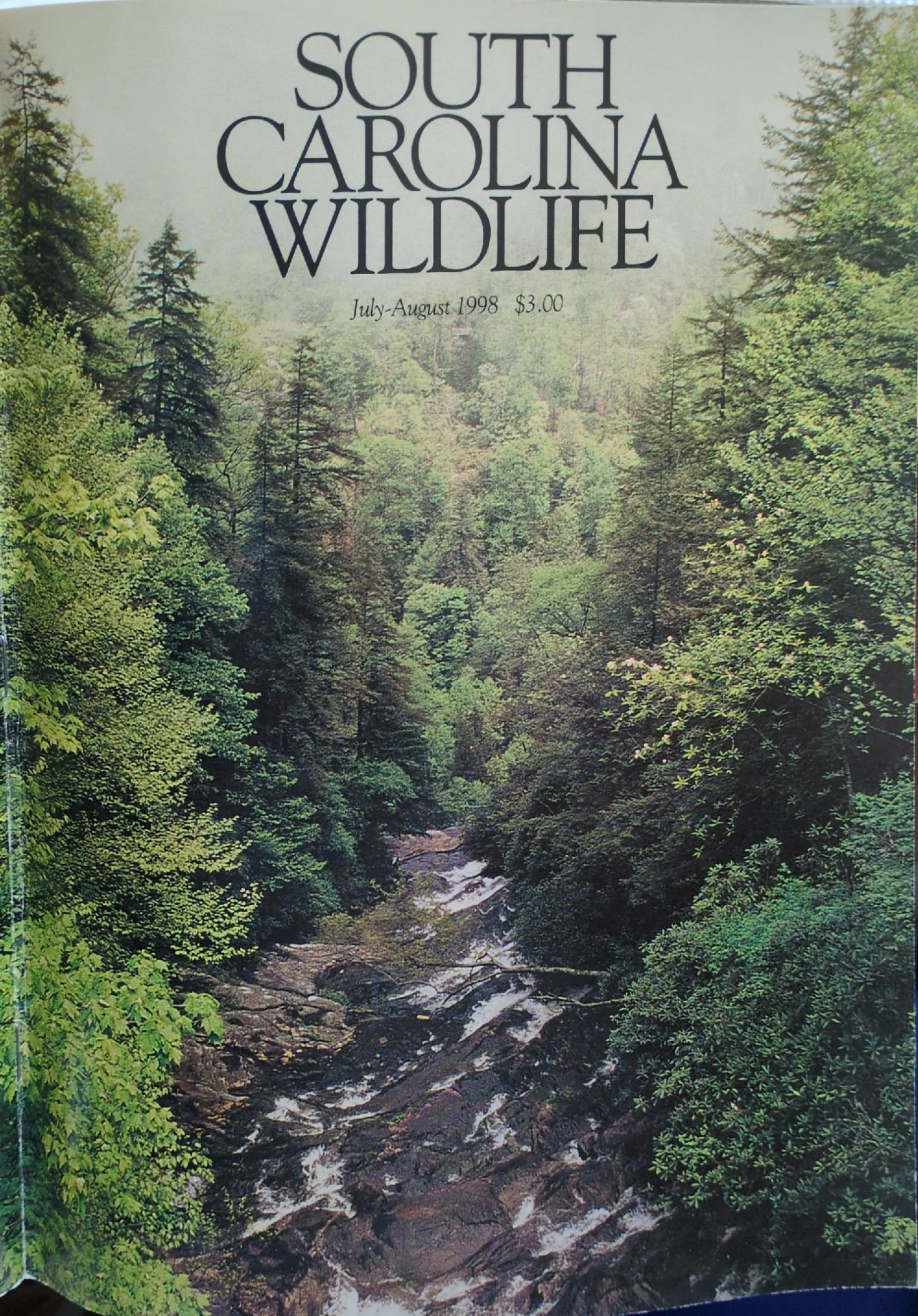


SOUTH CAROLINA WILDLIFE

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Help for Raptors

Eagles, hawks, owls and their kind appeal to humans' higher nature,

yet their interaction with us too often results in injured or orphaned birds.

Several Palmetto State rehabilitation facilities offer raptors a second chance at life in the wild.



by John Cely

photography by Phillip Jones

Jim Elliott grew up with a love for birds and other wildlife, but it was a visit to a live birds-of-prey exhibit at the Southeastern Wildlife Exposition in 1990 that turned his interest into a passion. Elliott soon found himself staring at many miles of blacktop between his home in Charleston and the Carolina Raptor Center in Charlotte, where he worked long hours as a volunteer and intern. After soaking up everything he could on raptor biology and rehabilitation, Elliott, a former commercial real estate salesman, decided a place to help birds of prey was needed a little closer to home, and in February of 1991 he launched the Charleston Raptor Center (later to become the South Carolina Center for Birds of Prey) literally in his back yard.

One hundred miles inland, Elizabeth Mackey of Camden remembers how she got hooked on raptors. She and her husband, Kelly, spent part of the summer of 1986 camped on the top of Table Rock Mountain as site attendants for the S.C. Department of Natural Resources' peregrine falcon hacking project under the leadership of biologist Jim Sorrow. A career as a science teacher led to more involvement with raptors and wildlife rehabilitation. She and friend Jimmy Woods saw a need for post-treatment raptor rehabilitation in the Midlands of the state and put together a series of flight pens and holding facilities. Later Mackey started the Sawney's Creek Nature Center, a nonprofit wildlife rehabilitation and educational organization.

Nadine Lamberski, staff veterinarian at Riverbanks Zoo in

Columbia, and Bob King, the zoo's raptor coordinator, preside over the BB&T Medical Clinic for Raptors and Endangered Species. Dr. Lamberski, King, and their staff can give the quick medical care and expertise needed by an injured raptor, attention that can mean the difference between a permanently crippled bird and a wild creature that flies free again.

In the Upstate, Tresa Adams, Lisa Pearson, Debra Woodey and Cat Monaghan have established a network to share information to help injured raptors. Veterinarians Gerald Orr, Sue Ann Hurlburt, Raymond Fay and others offer able professional assistance.

The Carolina Raptor Center, located outside of Charlotte, is the oldest raptor rehabilitation organization in the Carolinas and has played a role, directly or indirectly, in most efforts to help birds of prey in South Carolina. Nearly every raptor rehabilitator in South Carolina got his or her start through the excellent internship program offered by the center. They handle as many as five hundred birds a year, of which 10 percent may come from South Carolina.

It's easy to understand why these folks have given so much of their time and money to help birds of prey — that rather diverse group of predatory birds that includes the owls, hawks, falcons, kites, ospreys and eagles. Through the ages, raptors have inspired awe for their beauty, power, freedom, speed and fierceness. "Noble" and "majestic" are two adjectives we often associate with birds of prey.

Like most other top-level predators, though, raptors have taken their share of abuse. Their predatory instincts have put them at odds with gamekeepers, farmers and some livestock owners. Much of this animosity has softened over the years because of studies showing the beneficial role that raptors play in the balance of nature.

